

PROLOGUE: BYE BYE BYE

The ground was frozen. Not just cold—*frozen*. Like the heart of a Disney executive when you ask for an R-rating.

I slammed the shovel into the North Dakota permafrost. It made a sound like a gunshot wrapped in a wet towel. *Thwack-crunch.* My shoulders burned. My back screamed. My healing factor was working overtime, knitting torn muscle fibers back together just so I could tear them again with the next swing.

It's been a while since I did any manual labor that didn't involve disposing of bodies. Actually, this involves a body. Just... reverse disposing. Exhuming? Is that the word? Sounds fancy. Like a perfume that smells like old people.

I wiped sweat from my brow, smearing dirt across the mask. It smelled of pine needles, squirrel shit, and the looming specter of copyright infringement.

"Come on, Wolvie." I stabbed the earth again. "Don't be shy."

The grave of James Howlett. Logan. The Wolverine. The man who died saving a bunch of kids because he was just that kind of grumpy, self-sacrificing prick. I needed him. I needed the Anchor Being. I needed the guy who could help me save my world from getting pruned faster than a bonsai tree in a bored gardener's hands.

Clang.

Metal on metal. The sound vibrated up the shovel handle and rattled my teeth.

"Jackpot."

I tossed the shovel aside and fell to my knees, clawing at the dirt with gloved hands. I brushed away the soil until I saw it. The Adamantium coffin. Or, well, the box. Whatever.

"Okay, peanut. Time to wake up. We got work to do. We got a universe to save. We got—"

I pried the lid open. It shrieked, rusted hinges protesting the disturbance.

I looked inside.

And screamed.

Oh, come on. Really? You have got to be kidding me.

It wasn't a sleeping Wolverine. It wasn't a coma-napping Logan ready to pop his claws and say "Bub."

It was bones. Just... bones.

Shiny, metallic, indestructible bones. Ribs like the grill of a '58 Plymouth. A skull that seemed to be grinning at me, mocking my desperate, timeline-hopping stupidity.

"You died?" I asked the skeleton. "You actually died? In *Logan*? I thought that was just... artistic license! Oscar bait! You're Wolverine! You regenerate! You don't just—" I poked the skull.

"*Decompose.*"

I sat back on my heels, the cold seeping into my suit. *Well, Wade. You promised Vanessa. You promised the TVA guy—well, you headbutted him, but the sentiment was there. And now? Now you're sitting in a hole in the ground with a pile of very expensive scrap metal.*

"Freeze!"

The voice came from above. Mechanical. Amplified.

I looked up.

TVA Minutemen. A dozen of them. Standing on the rim of the grave, those little glow-sticks aimed right at my face. Pruning batons. The "Delete Key" of the multiverse.

"Wade Wilson." The lead agent raised his baton, the tip glowing with erasure energy. "Step away from the deceased Variant."

I looked at the agents. I looked at the skeleton.

Okay. Plan B. Or maybe Plan C. I've lost track.

I stood up, brushing dirt from my knees. "You guys. You picked a really bad time. I'm grieving here. This is my emotional support skeleton."

"Prune him," the agent ordered.

Music cue. Something poppy. Something that says 'I'm about to murder all of you with a dead guy's limbs'.

I reached down and grabbed the Adamantium femur. It was heavy. Dense. Balanced perfectly for blunt force trauma.

"Hit it," I whispered to the non-existent DJ in my head.

BYE BYE BYE START

I launched myself out of the grave.

The first agent didn't even see it coming. I swung the leg bone like a baseball bat. *CRACK.* His helmet shattered. The sound was wet—like dropping a melon on concrete. He folded, his body shutting down instantly.

Ooh. That felt good. That felt... resonant.

Two more rushed me. I ducked a glowing baton that sizzled the air where my ear used to be (before the cancer took it, anyway). I spun, driving the sharp end of the femur into the second guy's gut. The Adamantium didn't give. His armor did. He gasped, falling to his knees, wheezing like a pug with asthma.

Left swing. Right swing. Pirouette.

I was dancing. I was a beautiful, red-and-black ballerina of death, and my partner was a piece of the X-Men's most popular merchandise.

I jammed the skull onto a guy's head like a helmet, then punched it. *BONG.* He went down.

"I! Want! To! Be! With! You!" I sang, synchronizing the punches to the beat that only I could hear.

Another agent lunged. I grabbed Logan's claws—still attached to the hand bones—and *SNIKT*. I didn't have the muscles to pop them, but I could manually deploy the stabby bits.

I raked them across the agent's chest. Sparks flew. Armor parted like tissue paper. Blood sprayed, hot and copper-smelling in the freezing air. It misted on my mask. I tasted it through the fabric—salty, metallic.

This is it. This is the stuff. The physics of violence. It's not clean. It's messy. It's exhausting.

My breath was coming in ragged gasps. The suit was tight in the crotch. My heart hammered against my ribs like a prisoner demanding parole.

"I'm doing this for you, peanut!" I yelled at the scattered bones. "Don't think I don't appreciate the loan!"

I backflipped off a tree stump, landing on another agent's shoulders. I drove the leg bone down. *Crunch.* Collarbone. Goodbye.

The snow around the grave was turning red. A slushy, bloody mess. Steam rose from the fresh kills.

God, I love this job.

"Is that all of you?" I panted, standing amidst the carnage, holding the Adamantium claws in a dual-wield stance that looked cool as hell but was practically useless.

A portal opened. Orange. Rectangular.

More agents poured out.

Oh, good. The sequel.

I cracked my neck.

"Maximum effort." And then, because I couldn't help myself, I added, "And somebody check on the box office tracking. I think we just secured the opening weekend."

CHAPTER 1: THE COMMUTE

The air in the showroom smelled of stale coffee, floor wax, and the desperate optimism of sub-prime lending. It was a specific cocktail of scents, one that coated the back of Wade Wilson's throat like a film of cheap grease.

He adjusted his tie. It was a polyester monstrosity, wide enough to land a plane on, patterned with little sailboats that seemed to be sinking. It was the kind of tie a man wore when he had given up on being a superhero and decided that his true calling was moving mid-sized family vehicles with best-in-class safety ratings.

"So." The customer shifted his weight, testing the floor tiles with his heels. He was a man in his forties, soft around the middle, wearing a polo shirt that was tucked in aggressively tight. "Does it have the... you know?"

He made a vague hand gesture that could have meant anything from heated seats to a portal to the dark dimension.

Wade smiled. It was the smile he had practiced in the mirror for six weeks. The 'I am a trustworthy human being with a pulse and a credit score' smile. It hurt his face. Underneath the wig—a masterful piece of toupee engineering that sat on his scarred scalp like a nervous badger—his skin felt tight.

"The sliding doors?" Wade asked, voice smooth, devoid of the manic rasp that usually accompanied a katana swing. "Sir, let me tell you about the Carnival. It doesn't just have sliding doors. It has *automatic smart-power* sliding doors. You approach the vehicle with the key fob in your pocket? Boom. Sesame opens. No hands required. Because let's be honest, your hands are full. Groceries. Screaming children. The crushing weight of existence."

The customer blinked. "Right. The kids."

"Exactly." Wade patted the hood of the white minivan. It rang hollow, a tinny sound that echoed in the cavernous dealership. "Look at this bad boy. V6 engine. ample cargo space. You could fit... well, you could fit a lot of soccer equipment in here. Or lumber. Or, hypothetically, if you were a different kind of person, which you aren't, several duffel bags of non-sequential bills."

The man laughed nervously. "Funny guy."

Wade leaned back against the minivan. "I try." The humor felt dry in his mouth. Ashy.

This is it. This is the dream.

He looked out the plate glass window. The world outside was grey. Rain drizzled on the asphalt, turning the parking lot into a watercolor painting of misery. No explosions. No ninjas. No time-traveling cyborgs trying to kill a kid. Just cars. Just the endless, grinding cycle of commerce.

His wrist itched.

Not the skin. The bone. The place where the scars ran deepest, where the cancer had chewed on him like a dog with a bone. He rubbed it absentmindedly, feeling the lumpy texture through the cheap fabric of his suit jacket.

"Wade!"

The shout came from the manager's office. Gary. Or was it Larry? It was definitely a name that ended in a vowel sound that implied disappointment.

"Excuse me one moment." Wade pushed off the van. "Browse the infotainment system. It has Apple CarPlay. It will change your life. Or at least distract you from it."

He walked across the showroom floor. His loafers squeaked. *Squeak. Squeak. Squeak.*

The office was a glass box in the corner. A fishbowl for the big fish to watch the little fish swim in circles. Gary-Larry was sitting behind a desk that was too big for the room, staring at a spreadsheet.

"Wilson." He didn't look up. "Your numbers."

"Stellar? Astronomical? Defying the laws of physics?"

"Adequate." Gary-Larry looked up. He had eyes like a dead cod. "You sold the Honda Odyssey last week. That was good. But you're lagging on the upsells. The extended warranties. The undercoating."

"The undercoating is a scam, Gary," Wade said. "It's literally just spray paint and lies."

"It's *peace of mind*," Gary corrected. "And it's margin. We need margin, Wilson. You want to keep this job? You want to keep playing... whatever character this is?" He gestured vaguely at Wade's face. "Then sell the rust protection."

Wade stared at him.

For a second—just a microsecond—the world tilted.

He saw it. He saw the red targeting reticle over Gary's forehead. He saw the trajectory of a staple gun from the desk. He saw the cinematic slow-motion sequence where he vaulted the desk, kicked the ergonomic chair through the window, and rode the coffee machine into the sunset.

Do it, the voice in his head whispered. *Just a little maiming. As a treat.*

Wade swallowed. He forced the smile back onto his face. He locked the reticle away. He put the staple gun back in the drawer of his mind.

"Rust protection," Wade said. "Got it. Rust never sleeps. Neither do I. We're birds of a feather."

"Get back out there," Gary said, dismissing him with a wave.

Wade walked out.

He went to the break room. He poured a cup of coffee that had been sitting on the burner since the Carter administration. It tasted like burnt rubber and regret.

He leaned against the counter and closed his eyes.

He touched the locket under his shirt. The picture of Vanessa.

I promised, he thought. *No more chaos. No more violence. Just Wade. Just... this.*

He took a sip of the coffee.

It scalded his tongue.

"Ow," he whispered.

He opened his eyes. He looked at his reflection in the microwave door. The wig was slightly askew.

"You look great," he told the blurry reflection. "You look like a million bucks. Adjusted for inflation."

He straightened his tie. He walked back out to the floor.

"Sir!" he called out to the customer, his voice booming with forced cheer. "Let's talk about floor mats! You're gonna want the all-weather ones. Trust me. Life gets messy."

CHAPTER 2: A VERY WILSONS BIRTHDAY

The apartment smelled of cheap tequila, taco seasoning, and that specific, humid musk of too many bodies crammed into a space designed for two. It was a happy smell, theoretically. It was the smell of friendship. Of celebration. Of life continuing, despite everything.

Wade stood in the center of the room, holding a paper plate that was rapidly losing its structural integrity under the weight of a chimichanga.

"Surprise!" they had yelled.

And he had acted surprised. He had done the face—the widening of the eyes, the hand over the chest. He was good at acting. He'd been acting for years.

Blind Al was sitting on the couch, arguing with Peter about the viscosity of the guacamole.

"It's too chunky, Peter!" she shouted, waving a chip like a dagger. "It's like dipping a chip into a salad! I want paste! I want green sludge!"

"It's rustic, Al!" Peter beamed, his mustache quivering with wholesome delight. "It's artisanal!"

Wade looked around the room.

There was Dopinder, chatting up a girl who looked terrified. There was Negasonic, looking bored and fierce, tapping away on her phone like she was ordering a drone strike on the party. There was Yukio, radiating pink energy and genuine joy. There was Colossus, stooping to avoid hitting his head on the ceiling fan, holding a tiny red cup that looked like a thimble in his metallic hand.

And there was Vanessa.

She was by the window, laughing at something Buck said. The light from the streetlamp outside caught her hair, turning it into a halo of dark silk. She looked... radiant. Normal. Happy.

Wade felt a crack in his chest. A fissure running right down the center of his sternum.

You don't belong here, the thought whispered. It sounded like Stephen King reading an audiobook of his own suicide note. *Look at them. They're real. They're solid. You? You're a cartoon character drawn by a shaky hand.*

He took a bite of the chimichanga. It was cold in the middle.

"Wade!"

Vanessa saw him. She waved him over.

He walked toward her. The floorboards creaked under his feet—a sound he knew well. *Eeee-errrk.* The sound of home. Or at least, the sound of the place where he kept his stuff.

"Hey." He slid his arm around her waist. It felt natural, yet foreign. Like wearing a glove on the wrong hand. "Great party. Who invited the giant metal Russian? I thought we had a weight limit on the floor joists."

"Be nice." She poked him in the ribs. "He brought vodka. Good vodka. Not the stuff you buy in plastic jugs."

Wade shrugged. "I like the plastic jugs. They bounce when you drop them."

She looked at him. Really looked at him. Her eyes were dark pools, deep enough to drown in. "Are you okay, Wade?"

"Me? I'm fantastic. I'm the birthday boy. I'm... I'm just soaking it in."

"You seem... quiet."

"Quiet is my middle name. Wade Quiet Wilson. It's on my birth certificate. Or it would be, if I hadn't used it to light a cigar in 1998."

She touched his cheek. Her hand was warm. His skin—scarred, lumpy, hideous—burned under her touch. Not with pain, but with shame.

She sees you, the voice narrated. *She sees the monster under the wig. She sees the tumor with legs.*

She leaned closer, her breath warm against his ear. "I miss you."

Wade squeezed her waist. "I'm right here."

"Are you?"

The question hung in the air, heavier than Colossus.

Wade opened his mouth to answer with a joke. A deflection. A reference to *The Great British Bake Off*. But the words died in his throat.

Because she was right. He wasn't there. He was somewhere else. He was back in the grave, digging up bones. He was back in the dealership, selling lies. He was floating in the space between panels, waiting for the writer to decide what happened next.

"I'm trying," he said, and for the first time all night, it was the truth. "I'm trying so hard, Ness."

"I know," she said. She leaned in and kissed him. It was soft. Sweet. And it tasted like goodbye.

Someone knocked on the door.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Three sharp raps. Precise. Authoritative. Not the knock of a neighbor complaining about the noise. Not the knock of a pizza delivery guy.

This was the knock of Plot.

The room went quiet.

"I'll get it." Wade pulled away from Vanessa. He felt a sudden chill, a premonition that prickled the hairs on the back of his neck (the few that were left).

He walked to the door. He put his hand on the knob. The metal was cold.

Don't open it, the voice said. *If you open it, the genre changes. If you open it, the horror starts.*

Wade opened the door.

CHAPTER 3: THE KNOCK

The knock at the door was not a pizza.

Wade knew the sound of pizza. Pizza was a tentative *tap-tap-tap*, usually accompanied by the smell of pepperoni and the muffled bass of a car stereo playing reggaeton. This knock was three sharp, precise impacts. *Bang. Bang. Bang.*

It sounded like a judge's gavel. Or a coffin lid closing.

"I'll get it." Wade stood, smoothing down his toupee.

He opened the door.

Standing in the hallway were four men in armored suits that looked like they had been designed by a committee of fascists who really liked the color orange. They held batons that glowed with a menacing, violet hum.

"Wade Wilson?" the lead agent asked. He had a face like a thumb that had been smashed in a door.

"That depends." Wade leaned against the doorframe, crossing his arms. "Are you selling Girl Scout cookies? Because if you're out of Thin Mints, I'm going to have to ask you to leave. Aggressively."

"We are with the Time Variance Authority." Thumb-Face stepped forward. "You are coming with us."

"Time Variance Authority? Sounds like a department at the DMV. Look, fellas, I paid my registration. I even passed the emissions test, which, frankly, was a medical miracle considering my diet."

One of the agents reached for his belt.

Reflexes.

Wade's hand twitched. He saw the trajectory. He saw the baton arc. He saw the throat punch that would end this conversation in 0.4 seconds.

But he didn't move.

Wade Wilson, he reminded himself. *Car salesman. Boyfriend. Not a murderer. Not today.*

"Whoa, easy." He raised his hands. "I'm coming quietly. Just let me—"

The agent didn't wait. He shoved a glowing stick into Wade's chest.

It felt like sticking a fork in a toaster while taking a bath in a thunderstorm.

BZZZZT.

Wade's world went white. Then black. Then orange.

He was falling.

Not falling down. Falling *sideways*. Falling through colors that didn't have names. He tasted copper. He smelled ozone and old library books.

Thump.

He landed on a carpet that smelled of industrial cleaner and despair.

He groaned, rolling onto his back. He was in a room. An office. But not just any office. This was an Office with a capital O. Wood paneling that looked fake but expensive. Monitors that glowed with green text. A view out the window that showed...

"Is that a timeline?" Wade squinted. "It looks like a yarn ball made of pure energy."

"Mr. Wilson."

Wade sat up.

Sitting behind a desk that was roughly the size of a Kia Carnival was a man. He was wearing a suit that cost more than Wade's entire existence. His hair was slicked back. He had the face of a man who had never waited in line for anything in his life.

"I'm Mr. Paradox. Welcome to the TVA."

CHAPTER 4: PARADOX

"Paradox." Wade stood, dusting off his khakis. "Like two doctors? Or like when you park a pair of boats?"

Mr. Paradox didn't smile. He gestured to a chair. "Please. Sit."

Wade sat. The chair was uncomfortable. Intentionally so. It was a power chair. A chair designed to make your ass go numb while you were being told you were fired.

"You're probably wondering why you're here." Paradox steepled his fingers.

"I assume it's about the Blockbuster late fees. I swear, I returned **Jerry Maguire**. I rewound it and everything."

"This isn't about **Jerry Maguire**." Paradox tapped a key on his keyboard. A monitor on the wall flickered to life.

It showed footage.

Wade saw himself. But not **himself** himself. He saw Deadpool. Slashing through guys in a hallway. Shooting Francis. Cuddling with Vanessa.

"We have been watching you, Mr. Wilson." Paradox leaned back. "You are... unique."

"I prefer 'special'. Like the Olympics."

"You have soiled the timeline. You have jumped between realities like a flea on a dog. You used Cable's device to fix your mistakes. To save your girlfriend."

"And Peter." Wade held up a finger. "Don't forget Peter. He has a mustache."

"Technically, you should be pruned. Erased. Sent to the Void."

"But?"

"But." Paradox smiled. It was a shark's smile. "I see potential. I see a man who is wasted on a dying timeline."

"Dying?" Wade felt a cold knot in his stomach. "What do you mean, dying?"

"Your universe. Earth-10005. It is decaying. It is withering on the vine. It lost its Anchor Being."

"Anchor Being?"

"A specific individual whose existence is so pivotal that when they die, the entire timeline begins to unravel. Slowly at first. Then... all at once."

On the screen, an image appeared.

A grave. A wooden cross.

Logan.

"He died. And because he died, your world is dying. It might take a thousand years. It might take a week. But it is inevitable."

Wade stared at the screen. *Logan. That grumpy, hairy bastard. He really was the center of the universe.*

"So. We're screwed."

"Your world is." Paradox stood up and walked around the desk. He put a hand on Wade's shoulder. "But *you* don't have to be."

"I am offering you a ticket out, Wade. A chance to join the Sacred Timeline. The MCU. A world of heroes. Avengers. Gods. You can matter. You can be important."

Wade looked at the screen. He saw Thor crying over... him?

"Why is Thor crying?"

"That happens in the distant future. Don't worry about it." Paradox quickly turned off the screen.

"He was crying. Into my mask."

"The point is, you can leave the trash behind. You can save yourself."

"Save myself." Wade looked at the blank monitor. "And my friends? Vanessa? Blind Al? Dopinder?"

Paradox sighed. "Regrettable casualties. But necessary pruning. To grow the tree, one must cut the dead branches."

Wade looked at Paradox. He looked at the suit. The slick hair. The smug, bureaucratic soul of a man who viewed genocide as a spreadsheet error.

He wants me to let them die, the voice in Wade's head said. *He wants me to be a hero by letting everyone I love turn to dust.*

Wade stood up.

"You know. I've been selling cars for six years. I've heard a lot of pitches. 'No money down.' 'Zero APR.' 'We'll throw in the floor mats.'"

He walked over to the camera. He looked directly into the lens.

"But this? This is the worst deal in the history of trade deals."

He turned back to Paradox.

"I don't want to be an Avenger. I want to be an Avenger... *adjacent*."

He grabbed Paradox by the lapels.

"And nobody prunes my friends."

HEADBUTT.

CRACK.

Paradox's nose exploded. Blood sprayed across his pristine white shirt. He stumbled back, clutching his face.

"You... you broke my nose! In a TVA facility! That's... that's administratively impossible!"

"I'm unpredictable! I'm the X-factor! I'm the glitch in the system!"

He grabbed a TemPad from the desk.

"Where is the suit?"

"What suit?" Paradox gurgled.

"My suit! The red one! The tight one! The one that smells like crotch and justice!"

Paradox pointed to a locker in the corner.

Wade ran to it. He ripped the door open.

There it was.

Red. Black. Beautiful.

"Hello, lover."

CHAPTER 5: MAXIMUM EFFORT

Putting on the suit was like coming home.

It was more than fabric; it was an identity. When he was Wade Wilson, car salesman, he was naked. He was vulnerable. He was a cancer patient in a bad wig trying to pretend he wasn't dying inside.

But in the mask?

In the mask, he was a god.

He pulled the cowl down. The white eyes narrowed.

Deep breath. Smell the latex. Smell the baby powder. Smell the impending violence.

"Music. I need music."

He tapped the side of his head. The internal playlist booted up. The bass kicked in. Heavy. Aggressive.

He kicked the office door open.

"Knock knock, bitches!"

The hallway was full of Minutemen. They looked up, surprised.

"He has a weapon!"

"I *am* the weapon!" Deadpool drew his katanas. *SHING.* The sound was pure dopamine.

He charged.

The first agent swung a baton. Deadpool slid under it, his knees burning on the linoleum. He slashed upward. *Slice.* The agent's armor sparked and split.

Right. No killing. Just... maiming. Heavily.

Deadpool spun, kicking the second agent in the helmet. *CLANG.* The agent flew back, crashing into a water cooler.

"Hydrate or diedrate!"

More agents poured in. They were swarming. Like ants at a picnic where the main course was a mentally unstable mercenary.

Deadpool vaulted off a desk. He fired his Desert Eagles. *BANG. BANG. BANG.* He wasn't aiming for heads. He was aiming for knees. Shoulders. Hard drives.

"Sorry! Sorry! Not sorry!"

He grabbed a TemPad from a fallen agent. He looked at the screen.

Search: Wolverine. Status: Alive. Location: Anywhere.

The screen scrolled. Hundreds of results.

"Okay. I need an Anchor. I need a Logan. I need a beer."

He typed in a command.

Open Portal.

An orange rectangle fizzled into existence.

"Paradox!" Deadpool shouted over his shoulder. The bureaucrat was peeking out from behind his desk, holding a handkerchief to his bloody nose. "I'm gonna go find myself a Wolverine! And when I come back, we're gonna have a serious talk about your HR policies!"

Deadpool jumped through the portal.

The office vanished.

The silence of the hallway was replaced by the roar of the multiverse.

CHAPTER 6: THE HUNT

The multiverse, it turned out, smelled like ozone and desperation.

Wade fell out of the portal and landed face-first in mud. He spat out a mouthful of dirt.

"Okay. Universe 1. Let's see what we got."

He stood up. He was in a forest. It was raining. But not normal rain. It was movie rain. The kind that was backlit perfectly and made everyone look tragic.

He saw him.

Wolverine.

But not **his** Wolverine. This one was... short. Like, really short. He looked like a frustrated hobbit who hit the gym too hard.

"Hey, peanut. You look... compact."

The short Wolverine growled. It sounded like a chainsaw stuck in a log. "Walk away, Bub."

"I can't. I need you. You're the Anchor. You're the... wait, are you standing in a hole? Or are you just..."

SNIKT.

The claws popped.

"Okay, okay! Size doesn't matter! It's how you use the... oh god, he's lunging for my ankles!"

PORTAL.

Wade fell through.

Next stop.

A casino. Madripoor. Smoke hung in the air, thick and blue. It smelled of expensive tobacco and cheap morals.

There he was. Sitting at a card table. White tuxedo jacket. Eyepatch.

"Patch," Wade whispered. "Classic. Very Sean Connery meets a pirate."

He walked up to the table.

"Deal me in."

Patch looked up. The one eye was cold. "This is a private game."

"I'm a private guy. I just need you to come with me. Save a world. Be a hero. Maybe stab some people."

Patch took a puff of his cigar. He blew the smoke in Wade's face.

Then he retracted his claws *through* the table, skewering Wade's hand to the felt.

"OW!" Wade screamed. "That is a mahogany table! Do you have no respect for wood?"

PORTAL.

Next stop.

A dark alley. Rain again.

A figure on a cross. An X-shaped cross.

Wade stopped.

This wasn't funny. This was... iconic. It was the cover of *Uncanny X-Men* #251 brought to life in horrifying 4K resolution.

The Wolverine was crucified. Dying. Amidst a pile of skulls. The stench of decay was overpowering.

"Whoa. Okay. This is... heavy. Heavy metal album cover heavy."

The Wolverine looked up. His eyes were glazed. He was barely breathing.

"Help... me..."

"I... I can't." Wade's voice dropped. "I need a Wolverine who can fight. Not one who needs a tetanus shot and a hug."

He backed away. He felt dirty.

PORTAL.

Next stop.

A gym. Or a sterile room.

A man stood there with his back turned. Huge muscles. Wide shoulders.

"Logan?"

The man turned.

It was Henry Cavill. With a cigar.

Wade gasped. "The Cavillrine! You were the one who promised? The legends are true!"

Cavillrine pumped his arms—the reload motion. *Click-click.*

Claws popped.

"This feels right! This feels like efficient casting!"

Cavillrine punched him. Wade flew through a wall.

"Worth it!" Wade yelled as he fell into the orange void.

CHAPTER 7: THE BAR

The bar smelled like a mistake.

It was the kind of place where the floor was sticky, the lights were dim to hide the stains, and the patrons looked like they were one bad song choice away from a felony.

Wade walked in. He adjusted his mask.

He saw him.

Sitting at the end of the bar. A bottle of whiskey in front of him. He was wearing a jacket that looked like it had been dragged behind a truck. But under the jacket... yellow.

Wade walked over.

"Is this seat taken? Or did the last guy die of alcohol poisoning?"

The Wolverine didn't look up. "Get lost."

"Classic. The brooding intro. I love it. Look, I've had a day. I've met a tiny you, a pirate you, and a Superman you. I'm tired. I need an Anchor."

"I'm not an anchor." Logan swirled the amber liquid in his glass. "I'm a drunk."

"You can be both. Functioning alcoholism is a superpower. Ask my dad. Wait, don't. He's dead."

Wade reached out and touched the Wolverine's shoulder.

"Come on, Wolvie. My world is dying. My Vanessa... she's gonna be gone. I need you."

The Wolverine turned.

His face was a roadmap of scars and stubble. His eyes were bloodshot. But there was something else there.

Pain.

Real, deep, bottomless pain.

"I said." He slammed the glass down. "Get lost."

He extended a claw. Just the middle one.

"Cute. Very mature."

"I'm not going anywhere with you. I'm done. I failed. Everyone is dead because of me."

"Everyone?"

"Everyone. The X-Men. The humans. The dog. I let them down."

"Well. That's a bummer. But guess what? In my world, you're a hero. You died a hero. You have a statue and everything. It's a little generous with the bulge, but it's tasteful."

Logan chugged the whiskey.

"I'm coming with you. Whether you like it or not."

He pulled out his Desert Eagle.

"I'm gonna shoot you. And then I'm gonna drag you."

Logan laughed. A dry, hacking sound. "You think you can hurt me?"

"I think I can annoy you into compliance."

BANG.

He shot Logan in the head.

Logan's head snapped back. He slumped onto the bar.

"See?" Wade said to the terrified bartender. "Conflict resolution."

CHAPTER 8: PRUNED

Wade dragged the unconscious Wolverine into the TVA office.

"I found him!" Wade dropped Logan's heavy body onto the expensive rug. "I found the Anchor! He smells like a distillery, but he's breathing!"

Mr. Paradox looked up from his desk. He looked horrified.

"What is that?"

"That is the Wolverine. The Worst Wolverine, apparently. But he'll do. We'll fix him in post."

Logan groaned. He started to stir. The bullet hole in his forehead was already closing, pushing the metal slug out with a wet *plop*.

"You brought a Variant *here*? To the TVA? Do you have any idea the paperwork this creates?"

"Just put him in the timeline! Swap him out! Plug him in! Save my world!"

"It doesn't work like that!" Paradox shouted. "You can't just replace an Anchor Being! It's not a lightbulb, you idiot! It's a metaphysical constant!"

Logan sat up. He looked around. He looked at Paradox. He looked at Wade.

"Where the hell am I?"

"Space DMV. Don't ask."

"I told you." Paradox's voice turned cold. "Your world is dying. Mercy is a swift death."

He reached for a device on his desk. A pruning stick. But a big one. A Pruning Cannon.

"No!" Wade lunged.

Paradox fired.

But he didn't fire at Wade's head. He fired at the floor.

The floor dissolved.

Orange energy swirled. A hole opened up beneath them. A chute to hell.

"Enjoy the Void."

Wade fell.

Logan fell.

"YOU SON OF A BITCH!" Wade screamed as he tumbled into the darkness. "YOU OWE ME A VALIDATION STICKER!"

They fell for a long time.

They hit the ground hard. Sand. Dust.

Wade sat up, spitting out grit.

"Well. That went well."

Logan stood up. He popped his claws. All six of them.

"I'm gonna kill you."

"Get in line."

CHAPTER 9: THE WASTELAND

The Void didn't just look like the end of the world; it felt like it.

It was a landscape of discarded ideas. Broken monuments. Half-buried skyscrapers. The sky was a bruise—purple and angry, dominated by a cloud entity that roared like a hurricane made of lions.

Wade stood up. His suit was coated in grey dust.

"Okay. So. We're in the trash can. The cosmic landfill. Where bad plotlines go to die."

He looked at Logan.

The Wolverine was pacing. He looked like a caged tiger. He slashed a piece of rebar with his claws.

CLANG.

"Where are we?"

"The Void. It's where the TVA sends things they don't like. Like us. And apparently..." He pointed to a giant stone head half-buried in the sand. "Is that a giant stone head of... me? No. Too handsome."

"I don't care." Logan snarled. "How do we get out?"

"We don't. That's the point. It's a one-way trip."

Logan stopped pacing. He turned to Wade.

"You did this. You shot me. You dragged me here."

"I was trying to save my world! I was trying to be a hero!"

"You're not a hero. You're a joke. A clown in a red suit."

"And you're a disappointment! The Worst Wolverine! That's what he called you! What did you do, huh? Did you forget to tip? Did you scratch the furniture?"

Logan roared. He lunged.

He tackled Wade into the sand.

SNIKT.

The claws came down. Wade caught Logan's wrists.

"Whoa! Easy, tiger! Let's use our words! Or a mediator!"

Logan headbutted him. *CRACK.*

Wade's nose broke. Then healed.

"Okay. We're doing this."

He kicked Logan in the chest. Logan flew back.

Wade drew his katanas.

"Dance off, bro!"

They charged.

The clash of Adamantium on steel rang out like a bell. Sparks flew. Logan swiped low, gutting Wade. Wade slashed high, taking off Logan's cheek. They healed. They fought. They were trapped in a loop of violence, fueled by hate and regeneration.

CHAPTER 10: THE HONDA ODYSSEY

The fight had lasted for an hour. Or maybe a day. Time was weird here.

They were both exhausted. They were both bleeding. They were both healing.

"Call it a draw?" Wade panted. He was missing an ear. It was growing back, itchy and pink.

Logan was sitting on a rock, pulling a katana out of his thigh. "I hate you."

"The feeling is mutual. But look on the bright side. We have transportation."

He pointed.

Over the dune, a vehicle approached.

It was a Honda Odyssey. 2011. Gold.

"You have got to be kidding me."

"It's destiny! The Odyssey! The Chariot of the Gods! Or at least, the Chariot of Soccer Moms!"

The van stopped. A scavenger jumped out. He had a spear.

"Give me your boots!"

Wade shot him.

"Sorry. I need the van."

They got in.

The interior smelled of old Goldfish crackers, spilled milk, and resignation. It was the scent of a thousand school runs and family vacations gone wrong.

"Shotgun!"

"I'm driving."

"Fine. But I pick the music."

Wade turned the key. The engine sputtered to life. The radio turned on.

Avril Lavigne. 'I'm with You'.

"Yes!" Wade sang along. "It's a damn cold night! Trying to figure out this life!"

Logan slammed his head against the steering wheel. "Kill me. Again."

CHAPTER 11: THE BORDERLANDS

They drove for miles across the wasteland.

They passed the ruins of the 20th Century Fox logo. Wade saluted it. "Rest in power, you magnificent corporate entity."

They approached a settlement. It was built inside the ribcage of a giant skeleton. Giant-Man? Galactus? Someone big.

"That looks ominous. Let's go there."

"It's a trap."

"It's a plot point. We have to go. It's how we meet the villain."

They drove the Honda into the camp.

Scavengers surrounded them. Mutants. Variants.

Wade saw faces he recognized from the *X-Men* movies. Toad. Sabretooth. Pyro.

"Holy cameo. It's the Brotherhood of Evil Background Actors."

A woman stepped out.

She was bald. She wore a long coat. She moved with a grace that was terrifying.

Cassandra Nova.

"Well, well." Her voice was like velvet wrapped around a razor blade. "What do we have here? A talker. And a walker."

She looked at Logan. She licked her lips.

"I like the walker. He feels... heavy."

She raised a hand.

Wade felt a pressure in his head. Not just a headache. It felt like fingers—cold, slimy fingers—sliding *inside* his brain tissue. Rumaging through the filing cabinets of his mind.

"Get out of my head, Charles!"

"I'm not Charles. I'm his twin. The one who strangled him in the womb."

She flicked her wrist.

Wade and Logan went flying. They crashed into the sand.

"Welcome to the Borderlands. You're going to feed Alioth."

CHAPTER 12: THE FIRST CLASH

Cassandra's mind-fingers were disgusting.

Wade could feel them. *She's looking for my PIN number. Joke's on her, I don't have a bank account.*

"You're empty." Cassandra looked at Wade with disdain. "Just noise. And cancer."

She turned to Logan.

"But you..." She stepped closer. She placed her fingers on Logan's temples. "You are full of tragedy. Let's see."

Logan screamed.

"Get off him!" Wade tried to stand, but his legs felt like jelly.

"Quiet, pet." She didn't even look at him. She telekinetically slammed him into the ground.

Logan fell to his knees. He was weeping.

"I wasn't there," Logan sobbed. "I was drinking. They called me. And I wasn't there."

"Delicious. The guilt. It's like a fine wine."

Suddenly, a roar cut through the air.

Not Alioth. Not Logan.

An engine.

A car jumped over the bone-wall of the camp. It was a custom hot-rod. Fantastic Four style? No. Something else.

"Johnny? Is that Johnny Storm?"

A man jumped out of the car.

"Flame On!"

"Evans! Captain America! Oh my god, language!"

The man burst into flames. He flew at Cassandra.

"Run!" Wade grabbed the Wolverine. He dragged him toward the Honda Odyssey.

"We're leaving! We're escaping via the convenient distraction!"

They jumped in the van. Wade slammed it into reverse.

They sped out of the camp, leaving the chaos behind.

"Who was that?" Logan asked, wiping tears/blood from his face.

"That was the budget increasing."

He looked at Logan.

"You okay, peanut?"

Logan didn't answer. He just stared out the window at the purple sky.

"We have to kill her."

"Cassandra?"

"Yeah." Logan popped a claw. "She made me remember."

Wade nodded.

"Okay. Revenge mission. I like it. It's classic. It's simple. Let's do it."

He cranked the radio.

Grease. 'You're the One That I Want'.

"Really?"

"It's a banger. Now shut up and drive."